

Safeguard your work data

Steps you need to take to ensure business data is protected all the time

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If you're running a business, you of all people should understand the importance of data security and integrity. It doesn't matter how small or big a threat may be, or its type or nature, there will be consequences (reputation, legal charges, losing competitive edge, and other unforeseen damages) for any breach of your company's data and in some instances even irreparable damage. Unless you run a completely offline business, chances are that you have a fair amount of interaction with the web, which is rapidly becoming the top infection point for all sorts of security vulnerabilities. Seeing how security vendors are always releasing not-so-encouraging reports about the online threat landscape, it is important to understand and acknowledge the fact that unless protected your data is under constant threat.

There are a number of steps that one should take to safeguard and secure data before it's too late. We share a few basics that shouldn't be ignored.

Secure your network and connections

While working from home, how do you ensure that you connect securely to your office server for an urgently required file? Virtual Private Networks or VPNs is the answer, think of it as your very own private, completely secure tunnel through the internet. Windows 7 has a built-in VPN feature which you can explore (just



type "VPN" in the Start Menu field) to hook up two computers. You can also check out pretty good third-party solutions like OpenVPN or Hamachi which are free and easy-to-setup. For your wireless office network, don't ignore the basics: ensure you deploy WPA2 encryption with a difficult passphrase and MAC address filtering at the router level.

Encryption shouldn't be ignored at all

Make data encryption part of your work policy, whether you have two or twenty employees. Every computer that has business data on it should be encrypted at the hardware and software level to ensure

that even if a laptop is stolen or lost, the data on it is always encrypted and impossible to recover. Tools that let you do this are TrueCrypt, an open source favourite, and Windows' own BitLocker utility. Both of them are used to securely encrypt entire hard drive volumes with or without hardware encryption via TPM (trusted platform module), deploying different authentication methods.

Online backups are critical

If your office PC hardware is old or aging fast – disk drives whirring too loudly, with audible clicking sound – it's important to backup your data at short, fixed intervals before disaster strikes.